

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Early Christian Heresies

Heresy

The Greek word *hairesis*, which first means “choice,” refers to a sect or faction. For example, the Sadducees were a sect within Judaism, as were the Pharisees (Acts 5:17; 15:5). They called early believers in Jesus as the Messiah, “the sect of the Nazarenes” (Acts 24:5). In each of these verses, *hairesis* simply means a sect or denomination.

As the church expanded, they named any divisive group within a local church a *hairesis*. This term refers to a sect with beliefs opposing the truths taught by the apostles. Paul warned the Corinthian church that divisive sects would form among them (1 Corinthians 11:19).

Eventually, the word heresy came to mean teaching that departs from the norm and causes people to leave orthodoxy (traditional and established beliefs). Peter warned Christians about false teachers who would try to mislead believers with “destructive heresies” (2 Peter 2:1). Today, this is how the word heresy is usually understood. It refers to false teaching that harms the faith of some Christians and creates divisions within the church.

Two Early Heresies

Two major heresies were common in the church during the apostle John’s time: Gnosticism and Docetism.

Gnosticism

Gnosticism claimed to have special and secret spiritual knowledge. Many Gnostics believed in a hierarchy of beings. At the top was an eternal god, from whom came a series of lesser spiritual beings. Among these was the creator god, considered evil. This creator god made the material world, including humans.

Similar to the teachings of the Greek philosopher Plato, these Gnostics believed everything material was evil. A more “real” spiritual realm existed. Their goal was to find the spiritual “seed” within themselves through secret “knowledge” (Greek *gnōsis*).

This knowledge would help them leave the physical world and join the spiritual realm. This belief led to different responses to the physical world. Some Gnostics strictly avoided physical pleasure. Others freely lived for physical desires, seeing their actions as unimportant.

Gnosticism developed by combining Christianity with Greek philosophy. It stressed the need for special knowledge that changed traditional Christian beliefs and practices. Gnostics often included Christ in their beliefs. They considered Christ as one of many “streams” from a supreme being. Many Gnostics believed that Christ taught some followers to find their inner spiritual “spark” and connect with the spiritual realm.

Many Christian writings from the first two centuries countered Gnostic false teachings.

Docetism

Docetism was a type of Gnosticism. It taught that Christ only seemed to have a human body with physical birth, death, and resurrection. *Dokeō* is a Greek verb meaning “to seem.”

An early Docetist named Cerinthus claimed that the spiritual “Christ” joined the human Jesus at his baptism. He stayed during his ministry but left before his suffering and death. This movement hoped to protect God’s divinity from being stained by Jesus’ human nature. According to early church tradition, the apostle John strongly opposed Cerinthus’ teachings (see Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 3.3.4; compare 1 John 5:5–8; 2 John 1:7).

True Christians believe in the Incarnation when God became a real human with flesh and blood in the person of Jesus of Nazareth. Jesus’ humanity was real. He was truly human, sharing our flesh and blood, so he could save humanity through his own flesh and blood.

Ignatius was a student of the apostle John and later the bishop of Antioch. He wrote letters against Docetism. Ignatius was the first person after the New Testament writers to mention Jesus’ virgin birth. He also stressed that the apostles touched the body of their risen Lord. Ignatius said he could face martyrdom (dying for one’s beliefs) bravely because of Jesus Christ’s real suffering on the cross and his physical resurrection.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 8:9–24; 2 Corinthians 11:1–15; Colossians 1:23; 2:6–23; 1 Timothy 6:20; 2 Peter 2:1–22; 1 John 4:2–3; 5:5–8; 2 John 1:7–11; 3 John 1:9–12; Revelation 2:2, 14–16, 20–25

Eating Together

For the Pharisees and other practicing Jews, eating meals together was a religious event. Righteous Jews followed many rules to avoid ceremonial pollution during meals. They did this to show their commitment to the law, not to exclude others.

Most Jews obeyed the food laws most of the time. Jesus did as well. Yet, he often ate with people on purpose who were ceremonially unclean or less committed to obeying the law. Sharing a meal could show both covenantal and social equality (compare Matthew 26:26–29; 2 Kings 25:27–30). The Pharisees believed that avoiding such sinners was necessary for righteousness. This is why it offended them when Jesus ate with sinners (Matthew 9:10–11; 11:19; 21:28–32; Luke 7:36–50; 15:1–2; 19:1–10).

Jesus shared meals with sinful people to show God's grace. He extended God's love and forgiveness, inviting everyone to join a new community. Jesus's last meal (called "the Last Supper") anticipates the feast in the kingdom of heaven (Matthew 26:29; see 8:11–12). In the early church, communal meals also played an important role. They expressed communion among Christians and were an opportunity to partake of the Lord's Supper (Acts 2:46; 1 Corinthians 11:17–34).

The apostle Paul continued Jesus's practice to create a bond between Jews and gentiles (people who are not Jewish) in the church (see Galatians 2:11–21). Jesus tore "down the dividing wall of hostility" between Jews and gentiles (Ephesians 2:14–18). He calls us to community with all his people.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 18:1–8; Exodus 24:9–11; 2 Kings 25:27–30; Matthew 8:11–12; 9:10–13; 11:19; 26:26–29; Luke 7:36–50; 15:1–2; 19:1–10; 22:14–21; Acts 2:46–47; 1 Corinthians 11:20–34; Galatians 2:11–16; Ephesians 2:14–18

Empowering Leadership

In Acts 6:1–7, the early Christian community experienced a leadership crisis. The Hellenists were Greek-speaking Jews in Jerusalem. They were upset "because their widows were being overlooked in the daily distribution of food" (6:1).

This issue threatened the church's growth and needed serious attention. "The Grecian Jews among them began to grumble" (6:1). The apostles wisely identified the problem (6:2–3). They called for the selection of seven men to manage the food program (6:5–6).

Many believe these seven were the first deacons (see study note on 6:2–6). They agreed on a clear division of labor. The twelve apostles focused on preaching and teaching. The other leaders filled with the Holy Spirit dealt with material needs. The apostles showed strong leadership by listening to the community's needs. This wise approach and united action led to spiritual growth and additional Christians (6:7).

The church recognized different gifts and used them for the common good (see 1 Corinthians 12:4–11; 1 Peter 4:10–11). Every Christian has the chance to participate in some form of ministry. This idea of every Christian serving God is called the "priesthood of all believers" (1 Peter 2:5, 9; Revelation 1:6; 5:10; see Exodus 19:6; Isaiah 61:6; Revelation 20:6). While not everyone has the same role, God calls every person to use their gifts in God's service.

God has given the church its leaders, "not lording it over" the people, but to serve the community (Matthew 20:25–28; Mark 10:42–45; Luke 22:25–27; 1 Peter 5:1–4). Church leaders succeed when they understand the community's needs and identify those whom God has prepared to meet those needs. Good leaders recognize talented people and help them grow, enabling members to use their God-given gifts (Ephesians 4:11–12).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 19:6; Isaiah 61:6; Matthew 20:25–28; Acts 6:1–7; 1 Corinthians 12:4–11; Ephesians 4:11–12; 1 Peter 2:5, 9; 4:10–11; Revelation 1:6; 5:10; 20:6

Encounters with Jesus

Jesus' miracles and parables (symbolic stories with a special meaning) often take away the focus on his encounters with people that changed their lives. In these encounters, Jesus deals with individuals as they are. He invites people from all backgrounds to accept him as a leader and friend. He invites them to become his followers and messengers of his eternal kingdom.

Yet, following Jesus requires a choice. The world's power and wealth can be too distracting to transfer into kingdom service. Following Jesus means leaving something behind. Those who hold on to worldly things often end up rejecting Jesus. This choice challenges everyone who encounters Jesus in the Gospels and hears his call to follow.

Andrew was a fisherman in Galilee. He hoped for the Messiah (God's chosen one) and his kingdom to come. He followed John the Baptist until John showed him Jesus. Then Andrew followed Jesus and invited others, including his brother Peter, to join him. See John 1:29–42.

Simeon and Anna had waited a long time to see the promised Christ. When they saw the infant Jesus, they recognized him as the Christ. They blessed and thanked God for his arrival and the hope he brought. See Luke 2:25–38.

Nathanael was doubtful when first invited to meet Jesus. Yet, when Jesus demonstrated that he already knew him, Nathanael's attitude changed. He then followed Jesus without hesitating. See John 1:43–51.

A wealthy man approached Jesus and asked how to gain eternal life. This man showed humility and had already carefully followed all of God's laws. "Jesus loved him" but said he needed to sell all his possessions, give to the poor, and follow him. The man was unwilling to give up his wealth and sadly walked away from Jesus. See Mark 10:17–22.

Matthew abandoned his Jewish heritage, betrayed his people by collecting Roman taxes, and chose a life of wealth and luxury. When Jesus called Matthew to follow him, Matthew left his old life. Before traveling with Jesus, Matthew invited his friends to meet him. See Matthew 9:9–13.

Thomas did not believe the other disciples when they said Jesus had come back to life. When Jesus appeared to Thomas, he invited Thomas to touch his wounds. Thomas then bowed before Jesus and declared his belief that Jesus was his Lord and God. See John 20:19–29.

Martha was busy preparing a meal for Jesus at her home. She became upset because her sister Mary was sitting and learning at Jesus' feet. Jesus gently encouraged Martha not to be angry and explained that Mary had made the better choice by listening to his teaching. Later, Jesus spoke with Martha to affirm her faith in him for eternal life. See Luke 10:38–42; John 11:17–27.

A Roman officer asked Jesus to save his dying slave. He excused Jesus from visiting his ceremonially unclean home since he was a gentile and not a Jew. This was because the officer believed Jesus could heal by simply speaking. Jesus honored the officer's faith by healing the slave from a distance. Jesus also affirmed that many gentiles would enter the kingdom of heaven through trust in him. See Matthew 8:5–13.

Jewish leaders brought a woman accused of adultery to Jesus so he would judge her. Stoning was the expected punishment. Jesus wrote in the dust and asked any accuser without sin to throw the first stone. When they all left, Jesus told the woman to leave and stop sinning. See John 8:1–11.

Nicodemus was a Jewish religious leader and Pharisee. So he was careful about people seeing him with Jesus. So Nicodemus visited him at night. Jesus spoke with Nicodemus and challenged his beliefs about spiritual truth. Nicodemus later defended Jesus at the

Jewish council (Sanhedrin). After Jesus' crucifixion, Nicodemus helped bury Jesus, showing his commitment. See John 3:1–21; 7:50–52; 19:38–42.

James and John thought God's kingdom was near, so they asked for places of honor. This request upset the other disciples. Jesus kindly explained that true leadership is a matter of service, not wealth or power. The disciples would learn this lesson through difficult experiences. See Mark 10:35–45; John 13:1–17.

The people of Nazareth only knew Jesus as Joseph's son. They did not believe he could be the Christ. Their doubt greatly limited Jesus' miracles among them. Their anger at his claims gave him reason to leave. See Luke 4:14–30.

The religious leaders followed detailed laws focused on outward behavior. But they did not show love in more important ways. Jesus repeatedly challenged them about this. But most leaders rejected his criticism and sought ways to harm him. See Luke 11:37–54; compare Acts 6:8–8:1; 9:1–31.

Zacchaeus collected taxes for Rome and became rich by taking advantage of his people. He wanted to see Jesus, so he climbed a tree to look over the crowd. Jesus noticed him, visited his house, and invited Zacchaeus to change his life. Zacchaeus repented and repaid everyone he had wronged. See Luke 19:1–10.

Two followers of Jesus were returning home to Emmaus after Jesus' death. Along the way, the resurrected Jesus joined them and explained from Scripture why he had died. They did not recognize Jesus until he had meal with them. Then Jesus disappeared. The two joyfully left to tell the disciples that Jesus was alive. See Luke 24:13–35.

A Samaritan woman with a bad reputation went to Jacob's well to get water and found Jesus there. Jesus offered her "living water" and a new life. This surprised her but she believed him. Then she invited others to meet the Christ for which they had been waiting. See John 4:1–42.

The Jewish leaders pressured Pilate to kill Jesus. Pilate believed Jesus was innocent and tried to release him. Pilate asked Jesus, "What is truth?" But he did not understand that Jesus was the Truth. In the end, to maintain peace with the Jewish leaders, Pilate gave the order to crucify Jesus. See John 18:28–19:16.

Simon Peter denied knowing Jesus three times. After Jesus rose from the dead, he asked Peter three times if he loved him. Each time, Peter said he loved him. Jesus instructed him to care for his followers (his "sheep" and "lambs"). In this way, Jesus restored Peter to the

Christian faith. See John 21:1–23; see also Matthew 16:15–19.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 8:5–13; 9:9–13; 16:15–19; Mark 10:17–22, 35–45; Luke 2:25–38; 4:14–30; 10:38–42; 11:37–54; 19:1–10; 24:13–35; John 1:29–42, 43–51; 3:1–21; 4:1–42; 7:50–52; 8:1–11; 11:17–27; 13:1–17; 18:28–19:16; 19:38–42; 20:19–29; 21:1–23

Endurance

When Jesus was about to suffer and die, he told his followers they would also experience great difficulties (see Matthew 24:9). He emphasized the importance of endurance: “The one who perseveres to the end will be saved” (Matthew 24:13). Many New Testament writings were for Christians suffering for their faith in Christ (see, for example, 2 Thessalonians 1:4; 1 Peter 4:12–19). These Christians needed encouragement to persevere through difficulty while remaining committed to Christ and sharing their faith with others (see 2 Timothy 4:5; 1 Peter 4:1). Through endurance, Christians grow in character and develop spiritual maturity (Romans 5:3–4; James 1:2–4).

The book of Hebrews spoke to Christians who had encountered many challenges. People harassed them, took their property, and imprisoned them (Hebrews 10:32–34).

At the time of writing, they had similar issues. They needed to “hold firmly” to their beliefs without wavering (4:14; 10:23). They must endure while waiting for God’s promises to come true (6:12; 10:36). Like runners in a race, they needed to “run with endurance the race set out for” them (12:1). As true children of a loving father, they were to accept the Lord’s discipline to grow in holiness (12:5–13).

The great examples of endurance in Scripture, such as Job and the prophets, can inspire all Christians (Hebrews 11:35–40; James 5:10–11). Christ, our main model of endurance, “endured the cross,” because of “the joy set before Him” (12:1–3). This same hope for the future inspires us to endure.

Passages for Further Study

Romans 5:3–4; 1 Corinthians 4:12; 2 Thessalonians 1:4; Hebrews 6:12; Hebrews 12:1–10; James 1:2–4; James 5:11; 1 Peter 2:20

Enjoying God’s Gifts

The Teacher (the main speaker) in Ecclesiastes often concludes that we should enjoy life because it is a gift from God (see Ecclesiastes 2:24–25; 3:12–13, 22; 5:18; 6:9; 8:15; 9:7–9; 11:7–10). Even when life seems difficult, it is

meant for laughter, dancing, love, and peace. Life is especially valuable when old age and death threaten joy (9:4, 10; 11:7–9; 12:1). We should enjoy our food, drink, health, clothes, loving spouse, children, daily work, and times of rest.

Some people might be surprised to find such joy in Ecclesiastes since this book also talks about sad and frustrating things in life. But this mix of joy and sorrow shows wisdom. A wise person understands life deeply and sees how to live well even in an imperfect world.

When we focus too much on seeking pleasure, we actually make ourselves less happy. The Teacher warns that seeking pleasure alone is unwise and unprofitable (2:1–2; 7:4; 10:16–19; see also Isaiah 22:13; 56:12; Luke 12:19–20). The New Testament encourages us to find joy in everything, even during distress and challenges (Philippians 4:4; James 1:2). One tradition in Christianity says that “the chief end of man is to glorify God and enjoy him forever” (Westminster Shorter Catechism, Question 1).

Passages for Further Study

Ecclesiastes 2:24–25; 3:12–13, 22; 4:6; 5:18–20; 6:9; 8:15; 9:7–9; 11:7–10; Isaiah 22:13; 56:12; Luke 12:19–20; Philippians 4:4; Colossians 2:20–22; James 1:2; 4:13–16

Ethnic Hatred

Selfish pride, a desire to keep power, and hatred for those who oppose them have often led to the persecution of racial or religious groups. Many people have died over the centuries because of this hatred.

In the book of Esther, Haman hated Mordecai because Mordecai refused to bow down like everyone else when Haman passed by (Esther 3:1–5). Haman despised Mordecai, a man of integrity who would not follow laws against his beliefs. This personal hatred for Mordecai, a Jew, became a desire to destroy all Jews (3:6). The basis for Haman’s accusation against the Jewish people was what he did not like in Mordecai:

- They did not act like others,
- they had unique laws and customs, and
- they did not follow some of the king’s laws (3:8).

The Spanish Inquisition in the 1400s and the Holocaust in Nazi Germany during the 1930s and 1940s were terrible attempts to destroy the Jewish people. Religious and ethnic hatred still causes evil plans today.

God does not approve of hatred against any ethnic or religious group. He will eventually hold accountable those who make such evil plans (see Deuteronomy 30:7; Psalms 21:7–11; 34:19–21; 44:7). God has often

saved the Jewish people and defeated their enemies because he is faithful to all his promises (see Romans 9–11). He will also protect his church through all persecution (see Matthew 16:18; Romans 8:26–39).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 46:33–34; Deuteronomy 7:1–6; 23:3–8; Esther 3:1–9; Matthew 15:22–28; Luke 4:27; Acts 10:34–35; Romans 9:1–11:36; Galatians 3:26–29; Ephesians 2:14

The Exodus as History

Israel's view of reality was very different from other ancient cultures. Other major cultures around Israel, from Sumer in southern Mesopotamia in 2000 BC to Rome in AD 200, developed their perspectives by observing creation. They believed in many gods and thought events happened in endless cycles. In contrast, ancient Israel believed in one God, separate from the world. He created the world with a purpose and guides events to fulfill that purpose.

How did the Israelites develop this unique view? Was it through encounters with the true God in historical events? The most reasonable explanation for Israel's distinct understanding is that, as the Bible describes, God revealed himself to them through events recorded as history.

Egyptian texts do not mention the events described in the Bible, which makes some people doubt. Yet, it was uncommon for a powerful nation to record their defeat by slaves. The Bible's historical accounts, including stories of Israel's own failures, are unique in the ancient Near East.

Archaeology cannot prove specific events happened. But it can show that conditions allowed them to occur. This is true for the book of Exodus and the Bible in general. Egyptian records and archaeology do not confirm or contradict the Bible's account. Yet, the text of Exodus shows a deep understanding of Egyptian thought and culture, similar to a historical record.

The Bible's writers believed they were describing real events. They expected readers to regard them that way. Exodus 18:8–12 shows the first example of someone who trusted God because of a true story.

Faith in God and in the Bible has a strong historical foundation. God has acted in history to save humanity. His actions include Israel's escape from Egypt. These actions achieve their goal in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 14:15–15:21; 18:8–12; Judges 11:12–27; Acts 7:1–56